

The Benefits of Outdoor Exercise

Outdoor exercise has many advantages. Get some tips on getting fit while enjoying the great outdoors.

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There is no debating the health benefits of daily exercise. The U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, the American College of Sports Medicine, and the Surgeon General's Report on Physical Activity and Health all agree that we need at least 30 minutes of moderate to intense physical activity every day. The good news is that you don't have to work out in a gym to get in shape. Outdoor exercises are just as effective, can be more fun, and have some appealing advantages.

Reasons to Take Your Workouts Outside

Outdoor fitness can be a structured exercise program that takes advantage of the natural terrain of the outdoors to get you in shape, or it can be as simple as taking a brisk walk outside. Outdoor fitness can take many forms: Raking leaves, for example, is considered moderate physical activity. If you weigh about 135 pounds, you can burn close to 250 calories by raking leaves for an hour.

Whichever way you choose to exercise outside, there are numerous benefits:

- No membership fees. The outdoors belongs to all of us. "You don't need any special equipment — the outdoors is available wherever you are, just outside your door," says Tina Vindum, the author of *Tina Vindum's Outdoor Fitness: Step Out of the Gym into the Best Shape of Your Life* and the first outdoor fitness instructor accredited by the American Council on Exercise.
- The air is cleaner. The Environmental Protection Agency estimates that indoor air is more than twice as polluted as outdoor air.
- A free daily dose of D. Scientists recommend outdoor exercise as a way to get your vitamin D through sunlight. This is especially important if you are overweight — a recent study found that people who are overweight are almost twice as likely to be deficient in vitamin D.
- Exercise for your mind. "When you exercise outdoors, your mind becomes aware of the changing terrain. Whether you use the hills, the sand on a beach, or a winding path, your mind has to focus differently than it would on a flat gym floor," notes Vindum.

Getting Started With Outdoor Exercise

If you have any health issues, talk to your doctor before starting an outdoor fitness program. "I

tell my people to have a goal in mind, start slowly, and work up to their potential. Outdoor exercise can be adapted to anyone's level of fitness," advises Vindum.

Here are guidelines to get you going:

- **Exercise early.** "People can always find more excuses to avoid exercising outdoors at the end of the day," says Vindum. In the morning your energy is higher, the air is generally cleaner, the temperature is lower, and you will feel better all day long.
- **Avoid temperature extremes.** Although your body can adapt to colder or warmer weather, you should avoid exercising outside in extreme heat or cold.
- **Don't get burned.** Although some sun is good for you, too much sun is not. "Always protect yourself with a good sunscreen, and wear sunglasses and a hat with a brim," advises Vindum.
- **Drink enough water.** "If you drink about 8 to 10 ounces of water 30 minutes before doing outdoor exercises, it should hydrate you sufficiently for a 30-minute workout. You don't need water with electrolytes in most cases," says Vindum. Remember that you can lose water through sweating even in cooler weather, and you may start to get dehydrated before you feel thirsty.
- **Get some good gear.** "Take advantage of the new technology that has gone into shoe treads and waterproof, breathable clothing material," advises Vindum.
- **Make outdoor exercises part of your lifestyle.** "You can learn exercises that use only body weight and gravity and do them while you are walking to the post office," Vindum says. Think about walking instead of driving. Plan outdoor activities with your family. Go for a hike instead of a drive.

"Why would you need bottled aromatherapy when you can go outside and smell nature? Outside exercise uses all your senses and connects your body and mind. As you become more physically fit, your mind also becomes more aware. You start to look at life differently. It can be a life-changing experience," says Vindum.



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